

WEST

EDITION 2026–27

INFO BOOKLET

For *Parents*

What your son or daughter would do, who they would work with, what it costs and how they are supervised.

WEST VENTURES · AFFILIATED WITH AUSTIN CHRISTIAN UNIVERSITY

GOWEST.VENTURES

Cover: Emanuel Leutze, Westward the Course of Empire Takes Its Way, 1861 (study).

A LETTER

From the managing partners

Thank you for asking about West Ventures. This booklet is written for parents. It explains what a student does here, who they work with, how much time it takes, what it costs, how credit is awarded and how younger students are supervised.

The short version: your son or daughter would join a small team doing real work for an experienced founder or operator, for one term at a time, and earn academic credit for it. The studio's job is to make sure the work is real, the people are worth learning from, and the student is held to a high standard.

Everything in these pages is how the studio operates today. Where a detail is still being set, it says so. If something here does not answer your question, reply to the email this booklet came in and one of us will answer it.

Jake Oswald

MANAGING PARTNER

Lars Ostervold

MANAGING PARTNER

FOR PARENTS

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This booklet is written for parents. Four companion booklets cover the program for students, founders and executives, high schools and universities.

01 · THE STUDIO

What West Ventures is

A venture studio affiliated with Austin Christian University.

West Ventures finds young people with exceptional ability, puts them to work for proven founders and operators, and builds companies with them. It does three things, and each one feeds the others.

I

Teams

Small teams of high school and college students work on real problems for founders and operators, for academic credit. Companies pay nothing.

II

Companies

When a project turns up an opportunity worth building, the studio builds it with the operator who found it, as a joint venture.

III

Network

Partner high schools and universities send their best students. Founders, operators and investors bring the work.

23

Companies served by student teams so far

78

Students who have worked on a team

500

Partner schools planned by 2030

02 · THE MODEL

Kings and *cupbearers*



GUSTAVE DORÉ, NEHEMIAH VIEWS THE RUINS OF JERUSALEM'S WALLS, 1866. NEHEMIAH WAS CUPBEARER TO THE KING.

The thesis is not tied to an industry. The studio's advantage is its model: free work, done by a large group of the country's most capable young people, for the most experienced founders and operators.

The old words for the arrangement are kings and cupbearers. Kings are proven owners and operators with more opportunities than time. Cupbearers are capable young people who need real work and someone to learn from. The studio's job is to match them, at scale.

The arrangement works because each side gets what it lacks. Founders get capable help, at no cost, on work they have no time for. Students get real work, someone to learn from and academic credit. And when a project turns up an opportunity worth building, the studio builds it with the operator who found it, as a joint venture. It expects to start about six companies a year this way.

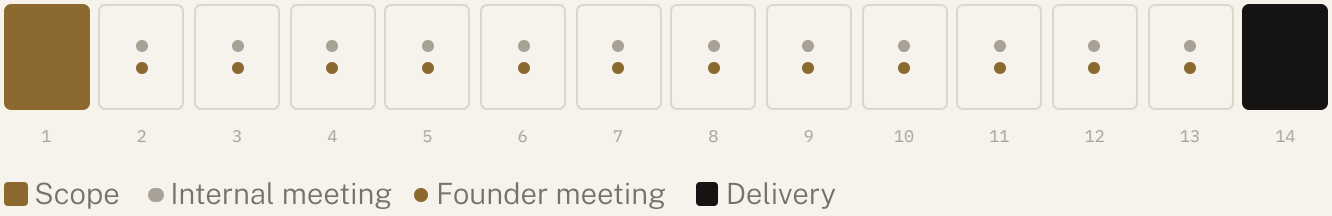
03 · HOW A PROJECT WORKS

How a project works

One team, one founder, one term, one written scope.

A project is one term of work by one team, for one founder or executive. Terms run in fall, spring and summer. The founder brings a real problem and about an hour a week. The company pays nothing and keeps all equity and intellectual property. Students earn academic credit.

A FALL OR SPRING TERM



Before	The studio matches the project with a team and a project advisor, and introduces them to the founder.
Week one	The founder and the project advisor write the scope: a week-by-week plan of what the team will deliver.
Every week	Two meetings. One internal, with the project advisor, on tasks and blockers. One with the founder, to review the work and adjust the scope.
End of term	The team delivers and hands over. The project advisor evaluates each student; the founder evaluates the project.
After	Students who delivered are invited back with more responsibility. An opportunity worth building may become a joint venture.

04 · THE TEAM

The team

About five students, an experienced project advisor and the founder.



Two college students, one of whom leads the team.

Three high school Builder Scholars, nominated by their schools.

Two roles are easy to confuse. The **team leader** is a college student who runs the team day to day. The **project advisor** is an experienced volunteer professional who coaches the team, keeps the scope honest and evaluates the work. Teams mix students from different schools on purpose, and studio staff oversee every team.

ROLES, TIME AND CREDIT

Team leader	College student	5 to 10 hrs a week	6 credit hours
Contributor	College student	4 to 8 hrs a week	3 credit hours
Builder Scholar	High school student	About 3 hrs a week	3 credit hours
Project advisor	Volunteer professional	Two meetings a week	—
Founder	The company	About 1 hr a week	—

05 · EXPECTATIONS

What each party commits to

The arrangement works when everyone does their part. This is what each is asked to do.

Students

- Give the hours the role requires, every week.
- Attend both weekly meetings, prepared.
- Deliver what the scope says, when it says.
- Keep the company's information confidential.
- Represent the company and the studio well.

The project advisor

- Run the weekly internal meeting and coach the team.
- Keep the scope current and the founder informed.
- Hold students to the standard the founder expects.
- Evaluate each student's work at the end of the term.

The studio

- Recruit and screen students and project advisors.
- Match each project with a team that can deliver it.
- Handle all academic paperwork and credit.
- Oversee every team and step in when a project is off track.

Parents

- Know the weekly time commitment and meeting times.
- Encourage your student to keep commitments to the team.
- Raise any concern with the studio directly.

The founder

- Bring a real problem or opportunity that matters to the business.
- Write the scope with the project advisor in week one.
- Meet the team once a week and answer questions in between.
- Give honest feedback, including when the work falls short.
- Evaluate the project at the end of the term.

06 · OUTCOMES FOR STUDENTS

Outcomes for students

Responsibility is earned one term at a time.

01	**Builder Scholar.** A high school student on a team, nominated by their school. Earns college credit.
02	**Contributor.** A college student on a team, doing a defined part of the scope.
03	**Team leader.** Invited after a strong term. Leads the team day to day and answers to the founder.
04	**Fellow.** The studio's most trusted students. Fellows work directly with proven operators on the studio's own companies, two or three at a time.

78

Students who have worked on a team

21

Student Fellows named

2×

Gloo AI Hackathon won by ACU student teams, 2025 and 2026

Every student keeps a record of the work: a public profile listing each company they worked for, their role and what the team delivered, alongside academic credit on a transcript and a reference from a project advisor who saw the work.

07 · STUDENT STORIES

Student stories

Students don't need a business idea or a network. They need to show up and do excellent work.

Most 18-year-olds have poor business ideas and no network. The studio has both: opportunities found by experienced operators, and the founders, executives and investors behind them. A student raises their hand, is placed on a real project, and is judged on effort, attitude and the work itself. When they deliver, their network grows and opportunities follow. Here are eight of them.



Yakira Cardoso · *p. 11*
TEAM LEADER · COLLEGE STUDENT

CE

Cole Elzerman · *p. 12*
TEAM LEADER · COLLEGE STUDENT

PG

Preslee Gordon · *p. 13*
TEAM LEADER · UPPERCLASSMAN IN COLLEGE

CD

Connor Dore · *p. 14*
BUILDER SCHOLAR · SENIOR IN HIGH SCHOOL

JE

Jonah Elliot · *p. 15*
FRESHMAN IN COLLEGE

BP

Braden Peays · *p. 16*
FRESHMAN IN COLLEGE

LC

Lillia Caldroney · *p. 17*
BUILDER SCHOLAR · HIGH SCHOOL STUDENT

MW

Merci Wymore · *p. 18*
BUILDER SCHOLAR · HIGH SCHOOL STUDENT

STUDENT STORY · 01

Yakira Cardoso

TEAM LEADER · COLLEGE STUDENT

TO CONFIRM · YEAR IN COLLEGE



An all-night pitch deck, a first-place finish and a seat on a founding team.

Project	Adoption Is An Option
Role	Team leader
Competition	First place, $12,000
Now	Founding team, Adoption Is An Option

Yakira joined the student team working with John Knox, a founder and philanthropist who was launching a nonprofit, Adoption Is An Option. When the students were given a chance to meet him, she stayed up all night building a pitch deck so she could bring him her own thinking about the organization he was starting.

He was impressed enough by the students, and by Yakira in particular, that he created a series of opportunities for them. One was a TikTok ad competition he funded, with $25,000 in cash prizes and ads judged only on how they performed. Yakira took first place and $12,000.

He then asked her to join the founding team launching Adoption Is An Option.

STUDENT STORY · 02

Cole Elzerman

TEAM LEADER · COLLEGE STUDENT

TO CONFIRM · HEADSHOT

TO CONFIRM · YEAR IN COLLEGE

CE

From waiting tables to leading a company spinning out of Life Time.

Gloo AI Hackathon	First place, 2025 and 2026
Current project	Life Time
Result	About $1.2 million a year saved
Next	Helping lead the spinout

Two summers ago, Cole was waiting tables. Since joining the studio he has won the Gloo AI Hackathon in Boulder, Colorado, two years in a row, and has worked on and led a series of projects for founders and executives.

One of the projects he leads now is for Life Time. His team built technology that is saving the company about $1.2 million a year in overhead. It is being spun out as its own company to commercialize, and Cole will help lead it.

STUDENT STORY · 03

Preslee Gordon

TEAM LEADER · UPPERCLASSMAN IN COLLEGE

TO CONFIRM · HEADSHOT

TO CONFIRM · YEAR IN COLLEGE

PG

Leading two teams, and hired by the founders of one of the organizations she serves.

Projects	Commissioned, Best Buddies
Role	Team leader on both
Now	Part-time role with Commissioned's co-founders

Preslee has moved up through several projects and this fall leads two teams: one for Best Buddies, and one for Commissioned, a network of hundreds of Christian women entrepreneurs who gather each year to learn from one another.

Her Commissioned team helped put on this year's gathering. Working alongside the network's co-founders, she led the team well enough that they hired her as a paid, part-time member of their staff.

The event also introduced her to a great many women founders. She is learning to lead a team and deliver real value, and her network has grown faster than it could have any other way.

STUDENT STORY · 04

Connor Dore

BUILDER SCHOLAR · SENIOR IN HIGH SCHOOL

TO CONFIRM · HEADSHOT

CD

A high school senior with a paid role and a growing network.

Projects	launch.kids, The Care App
Focus	AI
Gloo AI Hackathon	Award and cash prize, 2026
Now	Paid role at The Care App

Connor is a senior in high school and a Builder Scholar. He contributes to two projects, launch.kids and The Care App, and his focus is AI. His skills have grown quickly from one project to the next.

At the 2026 Gloo AI Hackathon he competed on the Unify team, which won an award and a cash prize.

His work on The Care App led the company to offer him a paid role alongside school. Through it he was introduced to the creative director of Porsche, an advisor to the company, to work with him on using AI to build out the platform.

STUDENT STORY · 05

Jonah Elliot

FRESHMAN IN COLLEGE

TO CONFIRM · HEADSHOT

JE

A college freshman working as a fractional CTO.

Year	College freshman
Largest offer	$250,000 a year
Now	Fractional CTO for several companies
Rate	$150 an hour or more

Jonah is a freshman in college. Through relationships made in the studio, he has had several offers to work for companies. One was for $250,000 a year.

He now works as a fractional CTO for a few companies, alongside school, and each pays him $150 an hour or more. He keeps building his skills and his network on studio projects.

STUDENT STORY · 06

Braden Peays

FRESHMAN IN COLLEGE

TO CONFIRM · HEADSHOT

TO CONFIRM · SALE AND TERMS

BP

A track win as a freshman, and a company sold within six months.

Company	Unify
Gloo AI Hackathon	Best in agentic engineering, 2026
Outcome	Acquired · terms to come

Braden came into the studio as a freshman. At the 2026 Gloo AI Hackathon he won best in agentic engineering for Unify, the company he is building with the studio: one platform for nonprofits in place of a stack of separate tools.

He was approached about an acquisition and sold the company less than six months later.

STUDENT STORY · 07

Lillia Caldroney

BUILDER SCHOLAR · HIGH SCHOOL STUDENT

TO CONFIRM · HEADSHOT

TO CONFIRM · GRADE

TO CONFIRM · WHAT SHE HAS LEARNED AND BUILT

LC

A high school student's first term, working for a bank.

Project	Regent Bank
Role	Builder Scholar
First term	Fall 2026

Lillia is a high school Builder Scholar. Her first project, this fall, is for Regent Bank, on a team led by a college student and coached by an experienced project advisor.

Working for a bank has meant learning how a regulated business makes decisions, meeting with the bank's team every week, and learning the research, writing and AI tools the team uses to do the work. It has also put her in the same room as the people who run a bank, at an age when few students meet anyone like them.

STUDENT STORY · 08

Merci Wymore

BUILDER SCHOLAR · HIGH SCHOOL STUDENT

TO CONFIRM · HEADSHOT

TO CONFIRM · GRADE

TO CONFIRM · HER STORY SO FAR

MW

One term in, on a team building a care app.

Project	The Care App
Role	Builder Scholar
First term	Fall 2026

Merci is a high school Builder Scholar. She began her first project this fall with The Care App, on a team of college students and other Builder Scholars.

Like every new student, she started with a defined part of the scope, meets with the company each week, and is evaluated on what she delivers. Students who do that well are invited back with more responsibility.

08 · FROM FAMILIES AND TEACHERS

From families and teachers

PARENT TO BE COLLECTED

"A line from the parent of a Builder Scholar: what changed in their son or daughter over a term."

Name
Parent of a Fall 2026 Builder Scholar

TEACHER TO BE COLLECTED

"A line from a teacher or counselor who nominated students: why they nominated them and what came back."

Name
Teacher, partner high school

STUDENT TO BE COLLECTED

"A line from a Builder Scholar about the work they did and who they did it for."

Name
Builder Scholar, Fall 2026

STUDENT TO BE COLLECTED

"A line from a college team leader about leading a team for a founder."

Name
Team leader, Fall 2026

Families and teachers who would speak with a prospective family directly can be introduced on request.

09 · FROM FOUNDERS

From founders

"Cole has been outstanding on our startup — smart, technically capable, coachable, hardworking, and a true team player. His contribution reflects not only strong technical skill, but the character, humility, and mission-minded leadership ACU is developing in its students."

Paul Kent Graeve
Founder & CEO, Today Matters

"I've spent years working in Big Tech in Silicon Valley with the world's most premiere talent. The profile of the ACU student is unique. The world has a lot of knowledge, but it needs more wisdom. ACU students are showcasing a rigorously intellectual foundation coupled with a moral, Christian fabric — a combo the world desperately needs more of. I wouldn't hesitate to bring an ACU student on."

John Kronlokken
Founder & CEO, Evergreen / Ex-Corporate Strategy, Google

"As an entrepreneur, I wish I had the college experience that ACU is creating. ACU provides students the opportunities they need to become excellent, and the students are delivering on that opportunity. Coming into the engagement, I thought it would be predominantly mentorship. I was wrong. The students delivered tangible value to our organization the whole way through. Movements like this will inspire the next generation of leaders to believe God is in all things, including our work."

Anthony Ruffner
Founder & CEO, Turn

10 · PRICING

Pricing

$5,000

per student, per term.

The same price for high school and college students, who work on the same teams. Companies, partner schools and universities pay nothing.

Terms	Fall, spring and summer. Each is priced and enrolled separately.
A full year	$15,000 for all three terms.
Credit	3 credit hours a term for contributors and Builder Scholars, 6 for team leaders. Awarded through Austin Christian University.
Included	Team placement, a project advisor, and academic credit and its paperwork.
Scholarships	Need-based scholarships are available. Price should not keep a capable student out.
Effective	Summer 2027 and later. Earlier terms are priced under the current program.

ONE TERM

$5,000

3 credit hours (6 as team leader)

FALL AND SPRING

$10,000

6 credit hours (12 as team leader)

FULL YEAR

$15,000

9 credit hours (18 as team leader)

11 · STUDY ABROAD

A term *abroad*

Through Living and Learning International, students can live overseas for a term and stay on a team.

Living and Learning International is a faith-based study abroad provider that works with more than forty Christian colleges and universities. Students live in residential communities with resident staff, take courses whose credit transfers home, and live in the culture. West Ventures students can spend a term in one of its locations and keep working with their team remotely, building companies from wherever they are.

Quito *Ecuador*	0.18° S · 78.47° W
Rome *Italy*	41.90° N · 12.50° E
London *England*	51.51° N · 0.13° W

TO CONFIRM Locations, dates and costs are set by Living and Learning and confirmed with each student before a term abroad. Living and Learning's program fees are separate from West Ventures tuition.

12 · SUPERVISION

Supervision

Many Builder Scholars are under 18. This is how the studio works with them.

DRAFT POLICY · TO CONFIRM

ADULTS	Every team has an adult project advisor, screened by the studio, and is overseen by studio staff.
MEETINGS	Team meetings are scheduled in advance and held online. Parents may ask for the schedule at any time.
MESSAGES	Team communication happens in studio-managed team channels that staff can see, not in private messages between adults and minors.
TRAVEL	No travel is required. Optional in-person events for students under 18 require a parent's written consent and are chaperoned.
CONCERNS	Parents and students can reach the studio directly about anything, at any time, and will get an answer from staff.

The full conduct and safeguarding policy is available to any parent on request.

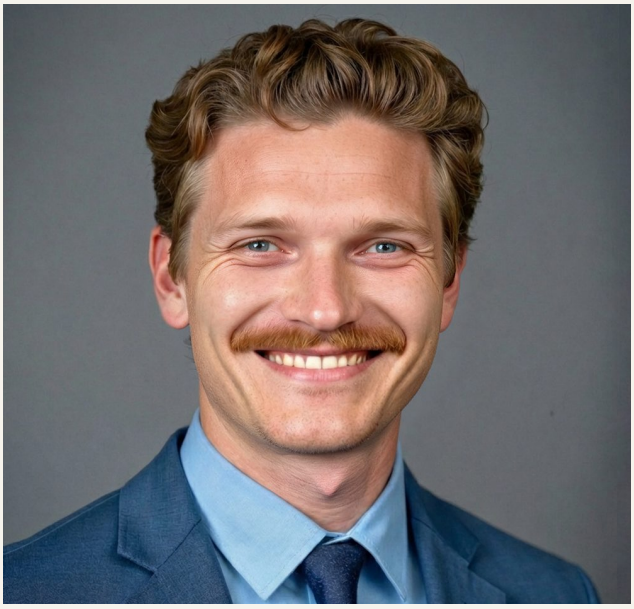
13 · LEADERSHIP

Leadership



Lars Ostervold

MANAGING PARTNER



Jake Oswald

MANAGING PARTNER

LEADERSHIP TEAM

Marshall Cunningham · Head of Operations

Tanner Dobbs · Head of Growth

Nate Steele · Head of Design

Taylore Hopkins · Head of Partnerships

Landen Enns · Head of Investor Relations

BOARD

Ben Peays · Board Chair

Connor Champion · Board Member

John Manning · Board Member

Ryan Wuerch · Board Member

Justin Forman · Board Member

Mark McClain · Board Member

Jake Thomsen · Board Member

14 · QUESTIONS

Questions

Is this a job or a class?

It is a course. Students earn academic credit through Austin Christian University for the work they do on their team. They are not employees of the company they work for, and they are not paid.

How much time does it take?

About 3 hours a week for a high school Builder Scholar, 4 to 8 for a college contributor and 5 to 10 for a team leader. There is no homework and there are no tests beyond the work itself.

Does my student have to live in Austin?

No. Teams work remotely and meet online. Students from partner schools across the country work on the same teams.

Who is my student working with?

A team of about five students, an experienced volunteer project advisor, and the founder or executive who brought the project. Studio staff oversee every team.

What if the work is too much alongside school?

Tell the project advisor early. Scope is set in the first week and can be adjusted. A student who cannot continue can withdraw under the university's course policies.

Is financial aid available?

Yes. The studio offers need-based scholarships. Price should not keep a capable student out. Ask about scholarships when you apply.

15 · NEXT STEPS

Next steps

1

Ask your questions

Reply to the email this booklet came in. A member of the studio will answer.

2

Apply or be nominated

High school students are nominated by their school or apply directly. College students apply directly. Applications are reviewed each term.

3

Meet the studio

Families can schedule a call with the studio before a student commits to a term.

CONTACT

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